

FAMILY LIFE

Family life for most birds is brief, but busy. After the female bird has mated, she lays her eggs, usually in a nest. The baby birds, or chicks, do not grow inside her because this would make her too heavy to fly. When they hatch, the chicks eat a lot, grow bigger and bigger, and then, as soon as they can fly, they leave home forever.

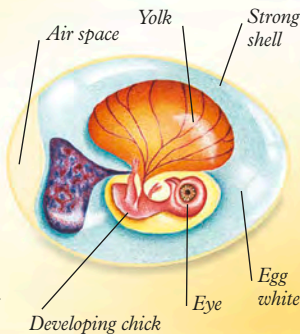


Baby sitting

Eggs must be incubated, or kept warm, otherwise the baby birds inside will die. The parents do this by sitting on them.

What's inside an egg?

All bird eggs have the same things inside them: a growing baby bird which feeds on a yellow yolk, and a watery egg white that cushions the chick from knocks. Woodpeckers and warblers are ready to hatch in 11 days, but Royal albatrosses take more than 11 weeks!



Ostrich eggs are the largest.



Hummingbird eggs are the smallest.

Peck, peck, peck . . .

Getting out of an egg is called hatching. The chick taps at the tough shell until it is free. This can take hours or even days!



The blunt end of the egg is pecked off by the chick with a horny spike called an egg tooth.

